



Right noise: Ayush has impressed the likes of P. V. Sindhu, who has called him a generational talent. *AFP*

While the final against China's Shi Yuqi did not go his way, Ayush believes there was plenty to take from it. Speaking to reporters in an online interaction, he said he was pleased with the aggression he showed throughout the tournament and, despite the loss, took valuable lessons from the final.

What's something that you feel you learned about yourself over the last week?

I learned that I need to keep trusting the process and believing in myself

— that was the most important part. This last week, I was really aggressive. I played a lot more attacking badminton, and that was a key point. I'm not usually this aggressive. I showed how much I wanted to win every match, and I'm happy I showed that aggression.

You actually didn't have a great start to the year [he'd only won four matches across seven tournaments since the season began]. What went right for you in Ningbo?

I actually had a very tough European tour coming into this tournament [he won just one match across the All England Championships, the Swiss Open and the Orleans Masters]. At

the start of the year also, I hadn't done that well, but that was because I was coming in with just about a week's training. I wasn't at my best physically then.

But going into the Europe leg, I was fully fit and felt I was at my best. It's tough to make early exits when you are physically at your best. I've been working with a psychologist, and I think that played a really important role in keeping my confidence high. After losing a number of matches in the early rounds, it was really important to keep believing in myself.

You beat several top-10 players at the Asian Championships. Even before the final, you had said you